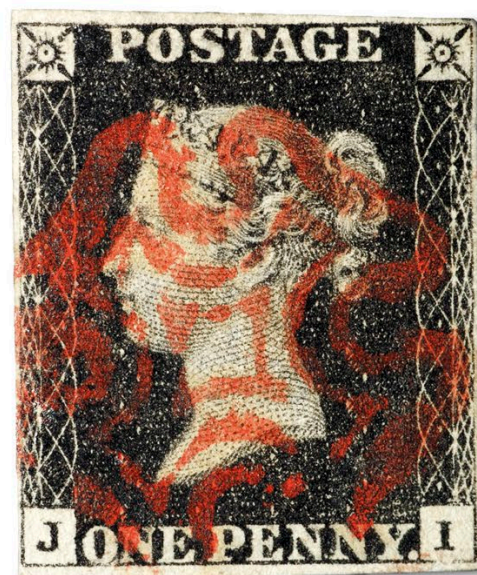


Written communication

People were communicating via marks inscribed on clay tablets 5,000 years ago in Mesopotamia (modern-day Iraq), and more than 2,000 years ago, on paper in China. The next great leap was not until about 1450 with the invention of the printing press in Germany. This paved the way for printed books, newspapers (introduced in the 17th century), and magazines (in the 18th century).

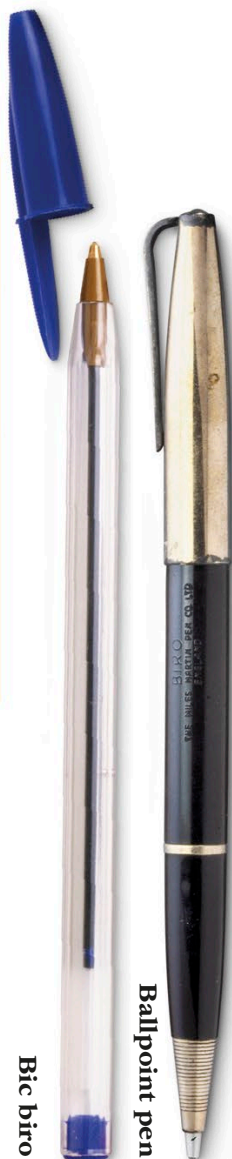
PENNY POST

Postal services date back to ancient times. However the first postage stamp, known as the Penny Black (right), was issued on May 1, 1840 in the UK, as a part of postal reforms introduced to make sending letters affordable for all.



A STEADY INK FLOW

Early pens had to be dipped in or filled with ink, which leaked or dried up. In the 1880s, American John J. Loud developed an early version of the ballpoint pen that had ink inside it ready for writing. This was later improved by the Hungarian László Bíró.



Bic biro

Ballpoint pen



In 1870, postcards were issued with a stamp as part of the design.

WISH YOU WERE HERE

The earliest known postcard was posted in London by the writer Theodore Hook—to himself—in 1840, using a Penny Black stamp. In the US, the first postcard-like piece of mail was sent in 1848 and was paid for by advertising printed on it.

German postcard, 1870